

EVIDENCE LOG

For PTSD (Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder) VA Disability Claims

THE SMOKING GUN EVIDENCE

After years of navigating the VA claims process—as veterans ourselves—we discovered something that changes everything: **the single most powerful piece of evidence you can submit isn't officially part of a Fully Developed Claim.**

"No more convincing. Just corroboration."

When you walk into a C&P; exam without this documentation, the examiner's job is to **investigate whether your condition exists and how severe it is**. They're playing detective. You're trying to convince them.

When you walk in WITH a properly completed Evidence Log, the dynamic completely shifts. The examiner's job becomes **corroborating what you've already documented**. They're not investigating—they're verifying. That's a fundamentally different exam.

HOW VA RATERS ACTUALLY EVALUATE YOUR CLAIM

Every VA disability rating—regardless of condition—is based on three core factors. Raters are trained to look for evidence of these specific elements:

FACTOR	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT RATERS LOOK FOR
FREQUENCY	How often do your symptoms occur?	Daily? Weekly? Constant? Episodic? Document specific patterns.
SEVERITY	How intense are your symptoms when they hit?	Mild, moderate, severe? Specific descriptions of pain levels, intensity of emotions.
FUNCTIONAL IMPACT	How do symptoms affect your daily life and ability to work?	Can't work? Can't sleep? Can't maintain relationships? Specific limitations.

Why This Evidence Log Works: The template you're about to use is specifically designed to capture all three factors in a format that's easy for raters to process. When a rater opens your file and sees 30 days of documented symptoms with frequency, severity, and functional impact clearly recorded, they don't have to guess or interpret. The evidence speaks for itself.

DO NOT FILE ANY CLAIM UNTIL THIS LOG IS COMPLETED AND INCLUDED WITH YOUR SUBMISSION

PTSD: CONDITION-SPECIFIC GUIDANCE

Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder is rated under 38 CFR § 4.130, Diagnostic Code 9411. The VA uses a General Rating Formula for Mental Disorders that evaluates your condition based on **occupational and social impairment**. Understanding what raters look for is critical.

What C&P; Examiners Are Trained to Document:

- **Re-experiencing symptoms:** Nightmares, flashbacks, intrusive thoughts, emotional/physical reactions to triggers
- **Avoidance behaviors:** Avoiding people, places, activities, conversations that remind you of trauma
- **Negative changes in mood/cognition:** Memory problems, negative beliefs, detachment, inability to feel positive emotions
- **Hyperarousal symptoms:** Sleep disturbance, irritability, hypervigilance, exaggerated startle response, concentration problems
- **Occupational impact:** Difficulty maintaining employment, conflicts with coworkers/supervisors, missed work
- **Social impact:** Relationship problems, social isolation, difficulty maintaining friendships

PTSD Rating Levels (What Your Log Should Demonstrate):

RATING	LEVEL OF IMPAIRMENT	SYMPTOMS TYPICALLY PRESENT
0%	Diagnosed but controlled	Symptoms controlled by medication, minimal life impact
10%	Mild, transient symptoms	Symptoms cause minor occupational/social impairment under stress
30%	Occasional decrease in efficiency	Depressed mood, anxiety, suspiciousness, chronic sleep impairment
50%	Reduced reliability and productivity	Flattened affect, panic attacks, difficulty understanding complex commands, impaired judgment
70%	Deficiencies in most areas	Suicidal ideation, obsessional rituals, impaired impulse control, difficulty adapting, inability to establish relationships
100%	Total impairment	Gross impairment in thought/communication, persistent delusions, persistent danger to self/others, inability to function

How to Use the Evidence Log for PTSD:

When documenting your daily symptoms, be specific and honest. Don't minimize or exaggerate. The goal is to create an accurate record that a rater can easily cross-reference against the rating criteria.

Strong Entry Example: "Woke at 0300 from nightmare about [trigger event]. Heart racing, sweating. Could not return to sleep. Irritable with wife at breakfast—snapped at her over minor issue, immediately felt guilty. Avoided driving past [location] on way to work because it triggers anxiety. Difficulty concentrating at work—had to re-read same email 4 times. Left work early (1400) due to overwhelming anxiety. Isolated in bedroom rest of evening."

Weak Entry Example: "Bad day. Didn't sleep well. Felt anxious."

The strong entry captures frequency (woke at 0300, left work at 1400), severity (heart racing, sweating, overwhelming anxiety), and functional impact (snapped at wife, couldn't concentrate, left work early, isolated).

COMPLETED EXAMPLE: 7-DAY EVIDENCE LOG

Below is an example of a properly completed Evidence Log. Notice how each entry captures specific details about symptoms, their severity, and their impact on daily functioning. Your log should follow this format.

DATE	TIME	SYMPTOMS & SEVERITY	FUNCTIONAL IMPACT
Mon 1/6	All day	Nightmare at 0230 (trauma-related). Woke in panic—heart racing. Only 2-3 hrs sleep. Spent 4-6 hrs by the window at night, unable to sleep.	Only 2-3 hrs sleep. Spent 4-6 hrs by the window at night, unable to sleep.
Tue 1/7	0600-2200	Intrusive thoughts throughout workday about [event]. Anxiety 6/10. Exaggerated startle response. Concentration dropped. Seemed "off." Avoided social situations.	Exaggerated startle response. Concentration dropped. Seemed "off." Avoided social situations.
Wed 1/8	All day	Emotional numbness. Felt disconnected from family. No nightmares. Still very "on edge" but slightly less intense.	Still very "on edge" but slightly less intense.
Thu 1/9	0300-EOD	Flashback triggered by car backfire at 0800. Panic attack in parking lot (panic attacks started on 1/8). Couldn't go to work. Spent 2 hrs in car, then drove to gym. Left 2 hrs before going inside.	Panic attacks started on 1/8. Couldn't go to work. Spent 2 hrs in car, then drove to gym. Left 2 hrs before going inside.
Fri 1/10	All day	Nightmare 0400. Avoidance—refused to drive route that passes [location] with anxiety 8/10. Kids asked why I was angry. Skipped planned activities.	Kids asked why I was angry. Skipped planned activities.
Sat 1/11	All day	Attempted to do normal activities. Anxiety 5/10 at hardware store. Couldn't complete errands. Slept 3 hrs (unusual). Drove to gym, but couldn't go.	Couldn't complete errands. Slept 3 hrs (unusual). Drove to gym, but couldn't go.
Sun 1/12	0200-EOD	Worst night—nightmare plus could not return to sleep. Total 2-3 hrs sleep. Spent 4-6 hrs by the window at night, unable to sleep.	Spent 4-6 hrs by the window at night, unable to sleep.

YOUR EVIDENCE LOG: 30-DAY TEMPLATE

Instructions: Complete one row per day for at least 30 consecutive days before your C&P; exam or claim submission. Be specific, honest, and focus on frequency, severity, and functional impact. Print additional copies as needed.

VETERAN NAME: _____ **CLAIM #:** _____

CONDITION: _____ **START DATE:** _____

DATE	TIME	SYMPTOMS & SEVERITY (nightmares, flashbacks, anxiety, irritability, etc.)	FUNCTIONAL IMPACT (work, relationships, daily activities)
Day 1 __/__/__			
Day 2 __/__/__			
Day 3 __/__/__			
Day 4 __/__/__			
Day 5 __/__/__			
Day 6 __/__/__			
Day 7 __/__/__			
Day 8 __/__/__			
Day 9 __/__/__			
Day 10 __/__/__			

Day 11 _/_			
Day 12 _/_			
Day 13 _/_			
Day 14 _/_			
Day 15 _/_			

EVIDENCE LOG CONTINUED

DATE	TIME	SYMPTOMS & SEVERITY (nightmares, flashbacks, anxiety, irritability, etc.)	FUNCTIONAL IMPACT (work, relationships, daily activities)
Day 16 _/_			
Day 17 _/_			
Day 18 _/_			
Day 19 _/_			
Day 20 _/_			
Day 21 _/_			
Day 22 _/_			
Day 23 _/_			
Day 24 _/_			
Day 25 _/_			
Day 26 _/_			
Day 27 _/_			

Day 28 __/__/__			
Day 29 __/__/__			
Day 30 __/__/__			

VETERAN CERTIFICATION: I certify that the information recorded in this Evidence Log is true and accurate to the best of my knowledge. I understand that false statements may result in denial of benefits or other penalties.

Veteran Signature: _____Date: _____

Witness (optional): _____Date: _____

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